Questions to Ask Before a Money Decision for Mom

What to bring to a Medicaid planner, an elder law attorney and a licensed insurance or financial professional: fifteen questions, with room to write what they say.

Your cousin has an opinion about Mom's savings. So does a neighbor. They mean well, and they may not know the rules in Mom's state or the details of her situation. The people below are the ones to ask.

Bring the questions written down, ask them as they are, and write the answer under each one. This guide doesn't answer them and doesn't say which matters most. That depends on Mom's state and her situation.

Your Medicaid planner

The person who looks at what a proposed money decision may mean for Medicaid before it is made, and who brings in an attorney or a licensed professional where a question belongs to one.

1. Do we really have to spend all of Mom's money before Medicaid can help? What does the answer depend on in her state and her situation?

2. Which of her assets may be countable, and which may not be? Do any already receive favorable treatment under the rules that apply to her?

3. Do any spend-down questions apply to her, and what would you need from us to look at them?

4. Are there permissible ways to preserve some of her assets that would be worth having evaluated?

5. What should we do with her money before applying for Medicaid?

6. Here is what our family has done with her money lately, and what we're considering. What would you want to review before anyone acts on any of it?

7. If Mom is married: what may the rules mean for her spouse at home, including the housing, the income and the savings?

8. Here are her debts, her regular bills, some expenses coming up for the house, and what we know about burial or funeral arrangements. Which of these would you want to go through with us?

9. Which statements, receipts and contracts would you want us to keep, and how should we note what has been paid?

An elder law attorney

Anything that needs legal review or legal advice belongs here. If you aren't sure whether a question does, bring it to your Medicaid planner first.

1. Which of the things our family is considering need legal review before anyone acts on them?

2. If our family is thinking about a gift, repaying a relative or changing the name on an account: what would you need to know about Mom's situation before advising on it?

3. What should we bring so you can see the whole picture: which papers, and which records?

A licensed insurance or financial professional

For questions about an insurance policy, an annuity, a retirement account or another financial product, whether Mom already has it or someone has suggested it.

1. Here are the insurance policies, any annuity and the retirement accounts Mom already has. What should we understand about each one before anything about it is changed?

2. Someone has suggested a financial product. What would you need to know about Mom's situation before saying whether it suits her, and how would we find out how it fits with her Medicaid plan?

3. How will you work with our Medicaid planner and our attorney, so that all of you are looking at the same picture?

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer these questions, and it doesn't say which one comes first. The answers depend on Mom's state and her situation, and they come from the people above. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You have your questions, sorted by who can answer them. The planning interview asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report, so you can bring the same picture to each of those conversations.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›